

DECENTRALIZED DIGITAL CURRENCY PROTOCOL MANIFESTO

The Better Money
Unconditional. Private. Sound.

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*“There is no such thing as perfect money.
But there is better money — and people deserve access to it.”*

*“The central bank must be trusted not to debase the currency,
but the history of fiat currencies is full of breaches of that trust.”*

— Satoshi Nakamoto

“Trusted third party is a security hole.”

— Nick Szabo

I. The Vision

1.1 There Is No Best Money

As disciples of Mises and Hayek, we begin with a conviction: there is no perfect money, and there is no single best money for all individuals, in all places, at all times. The nature of the economy is fluidity. Money is one good among many, and its value — like all value — is subjective, contextual, and mutable. The best monetary arrangement for any society is not a monopoly on money but a plurality of competing currencies, each with its own properties, each allowing individuals to opt in freely based on what they value.

Most people around the world have access to only one currency: the local legal tender their government has declared mandatory. Some have the luxury of accessing a dollar or a euro — occasionally through parallel or informal markets — as a means of protecting the value of their savings. But even the dollar and the euro, better than most, are not foreign to debasement, seigniorage, and an accelerating drift toward becoming instruments of state surveillance and individual control.

DDCP's mission is not to be the best money for everyone. It is to make The Better Money available to everyone — one option among competing currencies, with the best set of qualities a currency can offer not only for individuals but for society.

1.2 What Better Money Looks Like

Better money has four qualities, each reinforcing the others. None is optional. Together they define a standard that no existing monetary instrument — fiat, CBDC, or centralized stablecoin — currently meets in full.

Quality 1 — The Basics: Divisible, Portable, Fungible, Durable, Counterfeit-Proof

These are the foundational properties of money that every monetary economist agrees on. Banked people in developed economies take them

for granted: they pay and transfer money by transferring property rights over portions of their deposits, immediately and globally. Most people in the world do not have this access — they depend on cash that satisfies some of these properties but not all, and banking systems that marginally serve them. Better money delivers these basics to everyone, not as a privilege of geography or institutional access, but as a baseline.

Quality 2 — Fast, Cheap, 24/7 Payments With No Restrictions

This is the promise crypto stablecoins made to the world — and partially kept. Reduce the cost of payments and transfers, make them instant, make them available at any hour without waiting for a bank's business hours or a correspondent network's settlement window. The "no restrictions" element is the part the existing stablecoin market has not kept: every major centralized stablecoin today operates with restrictions that its issuer can apply at any moment, for any reason, with no prior notice and no appeal.

Quality 3 — Unconditional, Private and Free from Arbitrary Seizure

This is the most consequential quality and the hardest to deliver. The right to exchange value freely for goods and services — to transact without surveillance, to hold assets without arbitrary seizure, and to participate in the economy without submitting to political conditions — are fundamental individual civil rights, preconditions for the exercise of every other freedom. You cannot organize politically, support causes, practice religion, or make personal decisions with full autonomy if every financial transaction is visible to and potentially weaponizable by whoever holds executive power.

Free societies have navigated the balance between individual financial privacy and legitimate law enforcement for centuries, arriving at a settled framework: the state may investigate and seize assets, but only through judicial process, with individual targeting, evidentiary standards, and the right of appeal. That framework did not emerge by accident. It exists because unchecked financial surveillance and seizure are instruments of political control, not just law enforcement. Better money preserves this framework in the digital realm.

Quality 4 — Value Preservation

Going back to Mises: there is no such thing as stable value. The economy is in constant flux, and money is no exception. But there is more and less susceptibility to debasement, and more and less vulnerability to seigniorage and politically motivated monetary expansion.

Money began as a commodity anchor — grain receipts in Mesopotamia, silver by weight, gold coins — value rooted in what people actually consumed and needed. The long-term horizon of The Better Money returns to that foundation: purchasing power anchored not in any sovereign's decisions but in the real goods that sustain and drive the real economy. The energy that powers industries. The agricultural products that feed populations. The industrial inputs that build and wire the physical world. Value rooted in what people consume — not in what they believe others will pay for it, because that circularity collapses in precisely the moments when sound money matters most.

Gold, for example, cannot be eaten, worn in any meaningful quantity, or incorporated into construction at scale — its value is almost entirely a function of what others believe it will be worth, which is the circularity a consumption-anchored value preservation mandate is designed to avoid. The long-term horizon of The Better Money is value rooted not in financial convention but in what the real economy actually consumes and produces. That horizon is what this protocol aims to keep open.

II. The Problem: Money as an Instrument of Control

2.1 The Pattern Is Not New — and Not Ideological

The seizure of privately held savings by governments is not a characteristic of authoritarian regimes acting outside their legal framework. It is a recurring feature of democratic governance when a state's financial needs converge with the structural accessibility of private assets. The pattern does not require bad intent. It requires only opportunity.

In April 1933, the United States government — a democratic republic with a written constitution, an independent judiciary, and a tradition of property rights — issued Executive Order 6102, requiring every American citizen to

surrender their privately held gold to the Federal Reserve at a fixed exchange rate, under penalty of criminal prosecution. Gold was reachable through the banking system for bank-held deposits, and through the force of criminal law for privately held coins and bars. Gold was not seized from criminals. It was confiscated from every citizen who held it, regardless of how it was obtained or what individual circumstances surrounded it.

In 2008, the Argentine government nationalized the country's private pension system. Individual retirement accounts — contributions accumulated over working lifetimes by private citizens — were converted by a legislative majority controlled by the governing party into state social security claims. No individual recourse. One Congressional majority, and a lifetime of private savings became a government obligation whose ultimate value would be set not by the contributions made but by whatever political conditions would permit.

These episodes are separated by seventy-five years and two continents, but they share a common structure: the government needed the asset; the asset was accessible through the financial infrastructure or legal system it commanded; no procedural obstacle stood between the political will and the result. The lesson is architectural: accessible savings are politically reachable savings, regardless of the form that access takes.

2.2 The Banking System: The Original Compliance Chokepoint

Modern banking formalized this accessibility into architecture. When you deposit money at a bank, you acquire a claim on the bank — a legal obligation denominated in currency. You do not own the money; you own a debt instrument from an institution that is licensed by, regulated by, and continuously supervised by the state. The bank's ledger is the authoritative record of your claim. The bank's solvency and cooperation are the preconditions for your ability to exercise it.

This architecture has produced genuine benefits: payment efficiency, fraud protection, credit infrastructure, economic coordination at scale. But it has simultaneously made the entirety of a society's financial claims

continuously accessible to whoever can issue instructions to the banking system. To reach an individual's savings, a government does not need to go to that individual's home. It needs only to instruct the bank.

The Canadian episode of February 2022 is the clearest modern demonstration of this property exercised in a fully functioning liberal democracy. The Canadian government invoked emergency powers to freeze the bank accounts of citizens who had donated to or participated in a lawful political protest — without individual court orders, without criminal charges, and on the basis of political participation rather than criminal conduct. The directive was issued to financial institutions. The institutions complied instantly, because their regulatory relationship with the government made non-compliance unthinkable and their architecture made compliance trivial.

The episode illustrates a structural property of centralized financial infrastructure: there is no judicial process that must occur before a freeze is executed. A government issues a directive; the bank acts on it; the account is frozen. Courts can review the legality of that action afterward — Canadian courts ultimately found the invocation of emergency powers unlawful — but a ruling that a freeze was illegal cannot unfreeze the weeks of frozen funds, missed payments, and real consequences that accrued while the legal process ran its course. Due process arrives after the harm. The freeze arrives first.

2.3 CBDCs: Formalizing the Architecture of Control

More than 130 countries have active Central Bank Digital Currency programs. The stated rationale is compelling: financial inclusion, payment efficiency, real-time settlement. Governments are right that their citizens want faster, cheaper, more accessible payments. Where CBDC advocates are either mistaken or disingenuous is in what they describe as the instrument delivering those outcomes.

A CBDC is not a digital version of cash. Cash is unconditional: it works for any transaction, in any location, for any person, without third-party approval. A CBDC is a digitally issued currency whose terms of use are set

and enforceable by the issuing authority. The capabilities being built into CBDC architectures globally represent not a new invention but the systematic encoding into monetary infrastructure of precisely the access capabilities that have historically been exercised situationally through the banking system. The CBDC proposal formalizes into money itself:

- Expiry dates — money that must be spent within a defined period or is forfeited, eliminating savings and mandating consumption on the state's schedule.
- Spending category restrictions — transactions for non-approved goods or services blocked at the infrastructure level, without the need for a court order or individual review.
- Geographic limits — money whose use is restricted to defined jurisdictions.
- Behavioral conditions — purchasing power made contingent on compliance with state-defined criteria. In China's deployed digital currency system, this linkage already exists in nascent form. In Western CBDC proposals, the infrastructure for it is being built, with the political decision to activate it deferred.
- Administrative freezes without due process — wallets blocked instantly by algorithmic flag or administrative directive, with no court order, no individual notice, and no right of challenge before the freeze takes effect.

As Max Raskin and Richard Epstein observed, the surveillance capabilities of such an architecture do not require authoritarian intent to produce authoritarian outcomes: administrations of every political character would be able to observe, restrict, and reverse any financial decision their citizens make. The danger is in the architecture, not in the character of any particular administration that inherits it.

The CBDC is not the future of cash. It is the conditional replacement for cash — delivering digital payment efficiency while removing the individual civil rights that make money an instrument of human freedom rather than state control.

2.4 Centralized Stablecoins: Going Backwards

The United States, through the GENIUS Act, chose a different path from CBDC: a regulated private stablecoin framework. This path is healthier in principle — private issuers rather than state-issued currency. But its implementation has produced instruments that are, in the relevant sense, already conditional money. The freeze function is not a theoretical capability. It is in active, daily use.

As of April 2026, Tether and Circle together have frozen more than \$4.5 billion across more than 10,000 accounts. These include, in many cases, legitimate enforcement actions. But the mechanism that enables legitimate enforcement is identical to the mechanism that enables illegitimate enforcement: a single administrative decision, executed instantly, with no judicial review required at the moment of execution and no prior notice to the affected party.

On March 23, 2026, Circle froze USDC balances in sixteen unrelated business hot wallets — exchanges, casinos, forex platforms, payment processors — in response to a sealed civil court order in a private commercial dispute. Among the frozen addresses was the ckETH Minter smart contract operated by the DFINITY Foundation — public blockchain infrastructure processing transactions for thousands of users who had no relationship to the litigation whatsoever. One compliance decision, structurally unlimited blast radius.

The problem is not that Circle complied with a court order. The problem is architectural: a single company, exercising a single administrative key, can instantly freeze the operational infrastructure of multiple unrelated parties — with no prior notice, no mechanism for affected parties to seek relief before the damage is done, and a blast radius limited only by what that key can reach.

The trajectory of technology development in this space is moving in the wrong direction. Emerging approaches are being applied to digital currency systems in ways that deepen the problem rather than resolve it. These approaches allow an issuer to enforce spending restrictions, freeze

functions, and compliance conditions on encrypted data — without ever decrypting a user's balance in the clear. Such systems claim to protect privacy in a narrow technical sense while giving issuers and governments more, not less, programmatic control over how money can be used. A currency whose ciphertext can be computationally conditioned is not private money. It is supervised money with better optics. Any architecture that retains an administrative key — regardless of how that key is implemented, including through encryption — preserves the structural properties that made the 1933 gold confiscation and the 2022 Canadian bank freeze possible.

2.5 Your Keys, Your Money?

“Not your keys, not your coins” states a mathematical property of cryptographic systems: whoever holds the private keys to a wallet controls what happens to its contents. In traditional banking, control flows from the regulator to the institution to the depositor — which is why a government can direct a bank to freeze an account without ever engaging the account holder directly. Self-custody inverts this relationship: control flows from cryptographic proof to the keyholder, and no instruction to a third party can redirect it.

The right to hold money without depending on any intermediary's cooperation is the digital equivalent of the right to hold cash. DDCP cannot prevent governments from passing laws. But the critical structural distinction is this: a law directing a custodian to hand over its records — as EO 6102 directed banks, as Argentina's 2008 legislation directed pension fund managers — is a single instruction to a concentrated intermediary. A law requiring individual physical access to each holder's private keys, at the scale of a society, is a different kind of enforcement entirely. It requires reaching every individual holder separately, not issuing one instruction to one institution. DDCP is designed to remove the concentrated intermediary from the equation — so that the gap between political will and financial control is the full distance between government power and individual private keys.

This distinction becomes precise when applied to centralized stablecoins. With USDC or USDT, you can hold the private keys to your own wallet — in the technical sense, you are the keyholder. And yet you do not truly own your money. An issuer that retains an administrative key at the token contract level, independently of any keys you hold, has made a specific design choice: your access to the value is conditional on their restraint.

Your keys grant you access to your wallet address. If the issuer holds a master key to the value inside, your control is conditional on their restraint — and restraint is not an architecture.

III. Our Commitments

DDCP's commitments are commitments to the four qualities of Better Money — not to a particular technical implementation, but to the direction the design is oriented and the lines it will not cross regardless of pressure. They begin with the commitment from which everything else follows.

Your Keys, YOUR Money — Truly Yours

Satoshi Nakamoto's contribution to the problem of sound money was not the invention of digital currency. It was the demonstration that digital property rights could be asserted through cryptographic proof and decentralized consensus, working toward the elimination of the trusted third party as the authoritative record-keeper.

“Not your keys, not your coins” is the foundational principle of self-custody in digital assets — the recognition that if you do not hold the private cryptographic keys to your digital wallet, you do not truly control your holdings. DDCP's first and most important commitment is to make the second half of that principle equally true: if you do hold your keys, you do truly control your money. Only you. Not the issuer. Not the government. Not any intermediary.

That second half is not guaranteed by any centralized stablecoin. You can hold your own wallet keys and still have your stablecoins frozen — because the issuer holds an administrative key that operates independently of any

keys you hold. The promise “not your keys, not your coins” protects you from custodial loss. It does not protect you from the issuer’s master key. The two sides of the principle are not symmetric: one is a property of cryptography; the other is, so far, only a property of restraint.

DDCP commits to making both sides real by design. No administrative override key. No master key held by any issuer, government, or intermediary. If you and only you hold the private keys to your DDCP wallet, then you and only you control the funds inside it — as a structural property of the protocol, not as a promise any company can keep or revoke.

On Unconditionality

The commitment to unconditionality flows directly from the commitment to genuine self-custody. A protocol that delivers “your keys, your money” as a structural fact must also never introduce the conditions that would hollow it out. We will never introduce, and will resist any proposal to build, any of the following into DDCP:

- Administrative freeze functions of any kind
- Spending restrictions limiting what value can be exchanged for
- Expiry conditions causing holdings to lapse
- Behavioral conditions making access contingent on compliance with external criteria
- General-purpose programmable logic deployable by third parties at the protocol layer — which would create vectors through which the above could be reintroduced

These are not implementation gaps to be filled later. They are architectural commitments — the negative space that defines what DDCP is. If a future version of the protocol were to include any of them, it would not be DDCP.

On Financial Privacy

Financial privacy is not a feature. It is a civil right — the right to exchange value, to hold savings, and to participate in economic life without being

subjected to permanent, automatic surveillance by the state or by any private entity that can be compelled to act as its proxy.

Five dimensions of financial privacy matter: the balance held in an account, the amount of each transaction, the identity of the initiating party, the identity of the receiving party, and the timing and frequency of activity. The stakes are immediate and personal. Not only your salary should be private; what you do with it — which doctors you see, which causes you fund, which businesses you build — is your private matter. Your business's supplier relationships and payment flows are competitively sensitive. Your personal spending reflects your beliefs, your health, your relationships. A monetary system without financial privacy does not protect any of these.

DDCP commits to building toward meaningful privacy across all five dimensions — privacy that is real for the overwhelming majority of legitimate users, and that preserves law enforcement access through judicial process rather than administrative override.

On Governance

The history of monetary systems is a history of sound rules bent under sufficient pressure. Monetary institutions subject to human discretion will, in moments of crisis or sufficient political pressure, exercise that discretion in ways that benefit whoever holds the pressure — not as a moral failing, but as a structural inevitability. The design question for sound money is not whether to trust the right people. It is how to build an architecture that remains sound even in the absence of trustworthy people, or in the presence of trustworthy people under sufficient pressure.

DDCP commits to designing its governance so that no single actor — governmental, commercial, or private — can unilaterally override the unconditional properties described above. No single crisis, no single government, no single legal system should be sufficient to override these properties — that resistance must be built in, not relied upon. The specific mechanisms of that governance will evolve with the architecture. The principle will not. Control must be distributed across parties with divergent

interests and political relationships, so that reaching a majority requires genuine consensus — not momentary power.

On Value Preservation

The long-term commitment is toward a value anchor rooted in the consumption basket of the real economy — globally traded productive commodities, the energy, agricultural products, and industrial inputs that people actually need. A value preservation instrument anchored in consumption has no sovereign who can debase it and no central bank whose commitment requires trusting. We commit to designing DDCP so that path toward THE Better Money remains open. How that horizon is realized — by whom, with what reserve composition, in what form — is a question the market will answer over time, consistent with the competing currencies framework this protocol enables.

DDCP Stablecoins are fiat-pegged and therefore subject to whatever purchasing power their reference currency retains or loses. This is honest, and it is sufficient for the majority of use cases: payments between any two parties regardless of where they are, remittances arriving without correspondent banking fees, payroll and contractor compensation across borders, access to stable digital value for anyone without a bank account, and trade and business operations on unconditional terms.

We commit to reserves that fully back each deployment at par. The reserve management function is separated from the issuance function by design and entrusted to an independent foundation — a structure that permits more binding rules and mandates than a commercial entity can sustain, operating without profit incentives that could compromise the obligation to maintain full backing. Each deployment's reserves are independently ring-fenced and publicly attested. No single government can freeze a decisive share of any deployment's reserve; no sovereign derives fiscal benefit from token demand.

On Honesty and the Long Game

We will document what the protocol cannot do and will not do. We will document known design boundaries and known risks. We will be transparent about the gap between the commitments described in this Manifesto and the properties delivered at any given moment. We do not promise outcomes we cannot deliver. We do not claim technical properties that have not been built.

DDCP aims for the adoption trajectory that creates its own protection. This is a long-horizon project, measured in decades. The individuals who need this most are not the early adopters of the next technology cycle. They are the younger generations facing monetary conditions that today's citizens cannot fully anticipate, in political circumstances that have not yet revealed themselves. We build for them.

There is no perfect money.

But there is better money — and people deserve access to it.

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